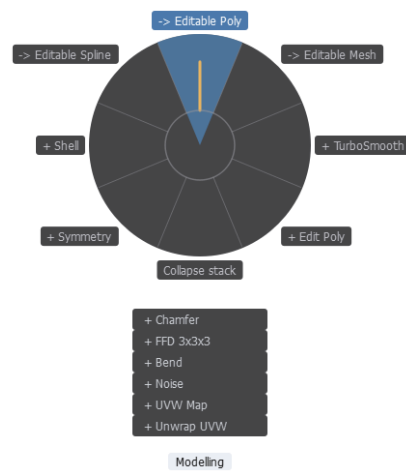


MarkingForge

QuickStart - the short version

3DS MAX 2027 · VERSION 1.5.36 · ABOUT 20 MINUTES



Only what you need to start: 9 short lessons. Everything else is in the full **QuickStart** and the **Reference - MarkingForge > Documentation** opens them.

Before you start

- 1 Look at the 3ds Max menu bar. You should see a **MarkingForge** menu.
- 2 Open **MarkingForge > Set up standard shortcuts...** It gives each dial its key, or says they already have one.

A dial is a round menu under a key

Hold

Alt+1

: eight commands appear around the mouse.

Aim, do not read

Move towards a command and let go of the key. Your hand learns the direction.

Nothing can go wrong

Let go in the middle, or press Esc: nothing runs.
Ctrl+Z undoes any command.

PART 1

Using the dials

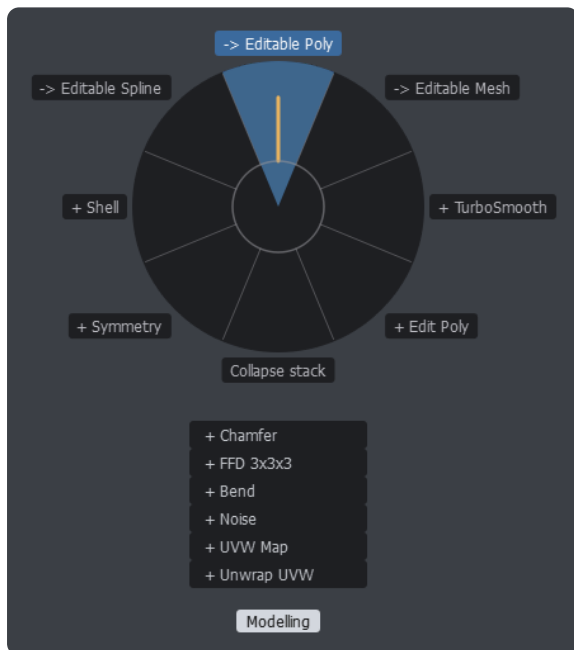
Five lessons. Open an empty scene and try each step.

1

Your first gesture

2 min

- 1 Mouse over a viewport. Hold **Alt+4** - the Create dial.
- 2 Move up to **Box** and let go. Drag a box in the viewport.
- 3 Click the box. Hold **Alt+1**, move up to -> **Editable Poly**, let go.



Alt+1, moved up: the box becomes an Editable Poly.

RESULT

Two gestures, no menus.

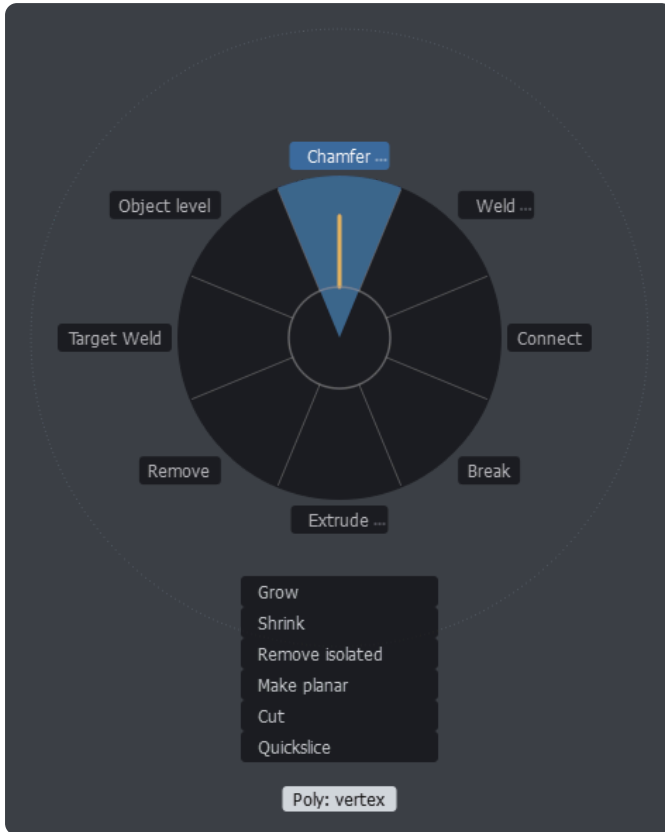
2

The dial changes with your work

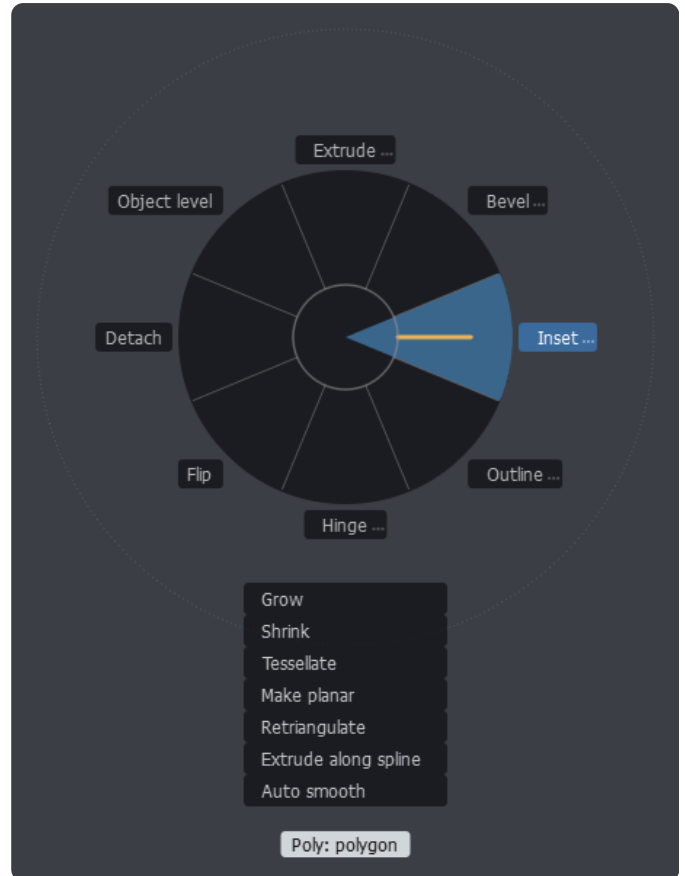
2 min

- 1 Press **1** (vertices). Hold **Alt+1**: now it shows vertex tools - Chamfer, Weld, Connect...
- 2 Press **4** (polygons). Hold **Alt+1**: Inset, Extrude, Bevel...

3 Move up-left (**Object level**) to go back to the whole object.



Vertices.



Polygons.

3

Flick - the fast way

2 min

Press the key and move **at the same moment**, then let go. The command runs and the dial does not even show. Try each one a few times:

Press, then move	What happens
Ctrl+Alt+7, up	Zoom to see everything
Alt+3, up / down	Select all / select nothing
Ctrl+Alt+1, up	Move tool
Alt+7, up	Undo one step

4

Near or far: the dotted circle

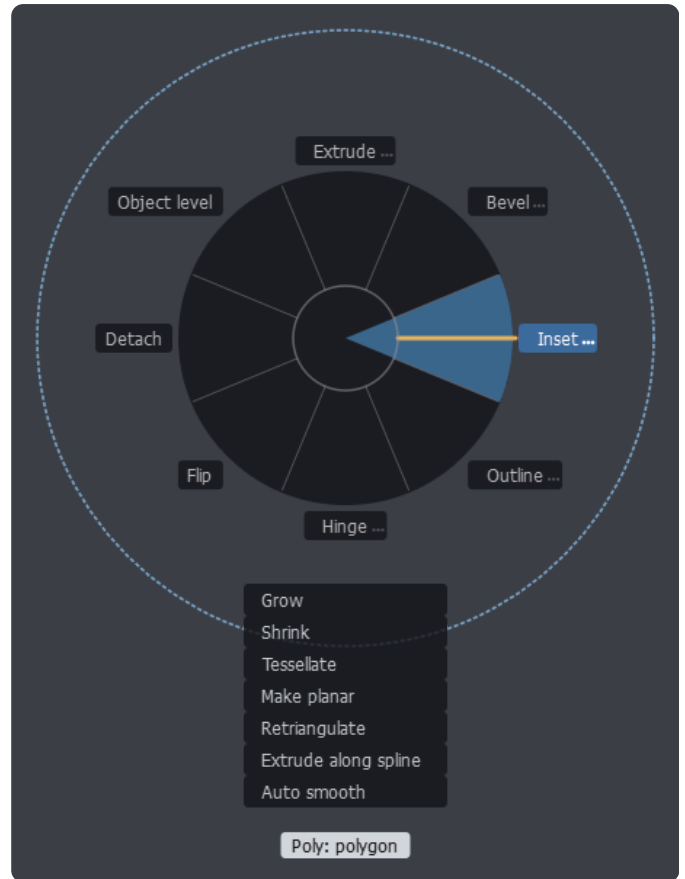
2 min

Commands with three dots (Chamfer..., Inset...) have a settings window.

- Let go **near** the dial: the command starts at once - drag in the viewport to set it.
- Let go **past the dotted circle** (it lights up): the settings window opens.



Near: Inset starts at once.



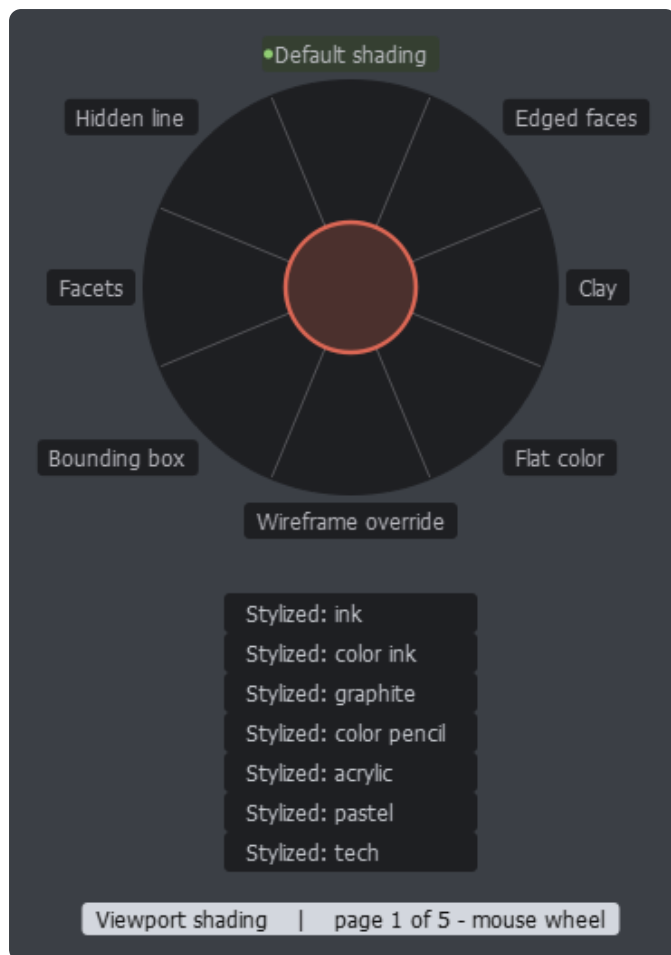
Past the circle: Inset's window.

5

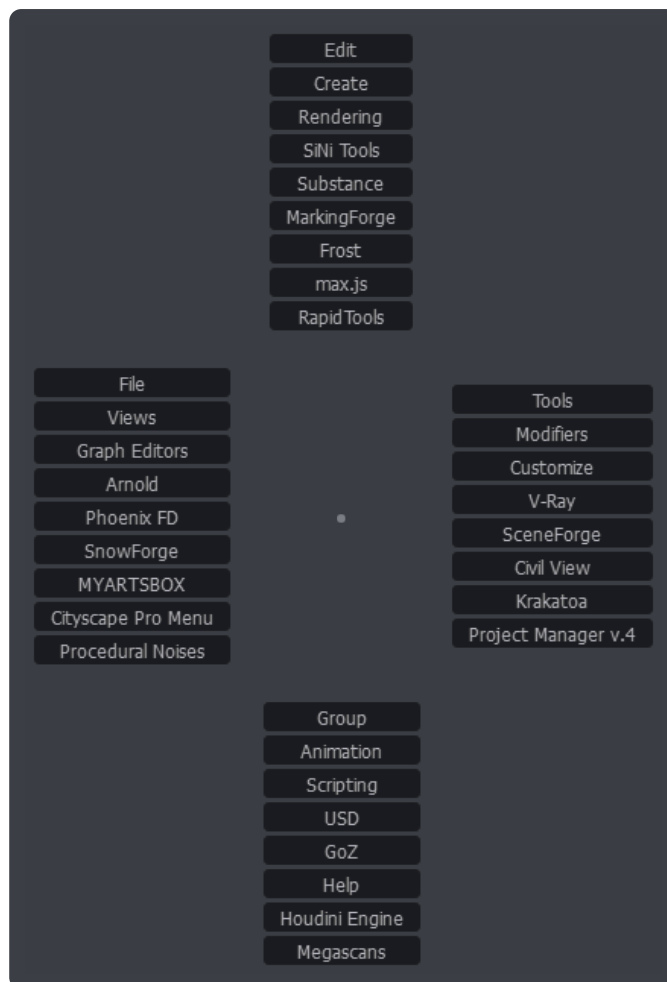
Pages, the hotbox and undo

2 min

- 1 Hold **Alt+5**: how the viewport looks. Keep holding and **turn the mouse wheel** - more pages (lights, what is shown, views).
- 2 Turn the wheel one step the other way: the **hotbox** - every 3ds Max menu as tiles. Esc closes it.
- 3 Hold **Alt+7**: your last steps by name. Pick one to undo back to it.



Alt+5 - the viewport.



Alt+5, wheel - the hotbox.

Which key is which

The number (1-8) is the place; **Alt**, **Ctrl+Alt** or **Shift+Alt** is the row.

Key	Dial	Key	Dial	Key	Dial
Alt+1	Modelling	Ctrl+Alt+1	Transform	Shift+Alt+1	Viewport display
Alt+2	Modifiers	Ctrl+Alt+2	Align and pivot	Shift+Alt+2	Selection sets
Alt+3	Selection	Ctrl+Alt+3	Lights and cameras	Shift+Alt+3	Materials
Alt+4	Create	Ctrl+Alt+4	UV mapping	Shift+Alt+4	Render
Alt+5	Viewport shading	Ctrl+Alt+5	Snaps and grid	Shift+Alt+5	Animation
Alt+6	Modifier stack	Ctrl+Alt+6	Show and hide	Shift+Alt+6	Scene
Alt+7	Undo	Ctrl+Alt+7	View	Shift+Alt+7	Tools and setup
Alt+8	Recent commands	Ctrl+Alt+8	Viewports	Shift+Alt+8	File

Print your own list: **MarkingForge > Dial cheat sheet (HTML + PDF)...** - keep it next to the keyboard for the first week.

PART 2

Changing the dials

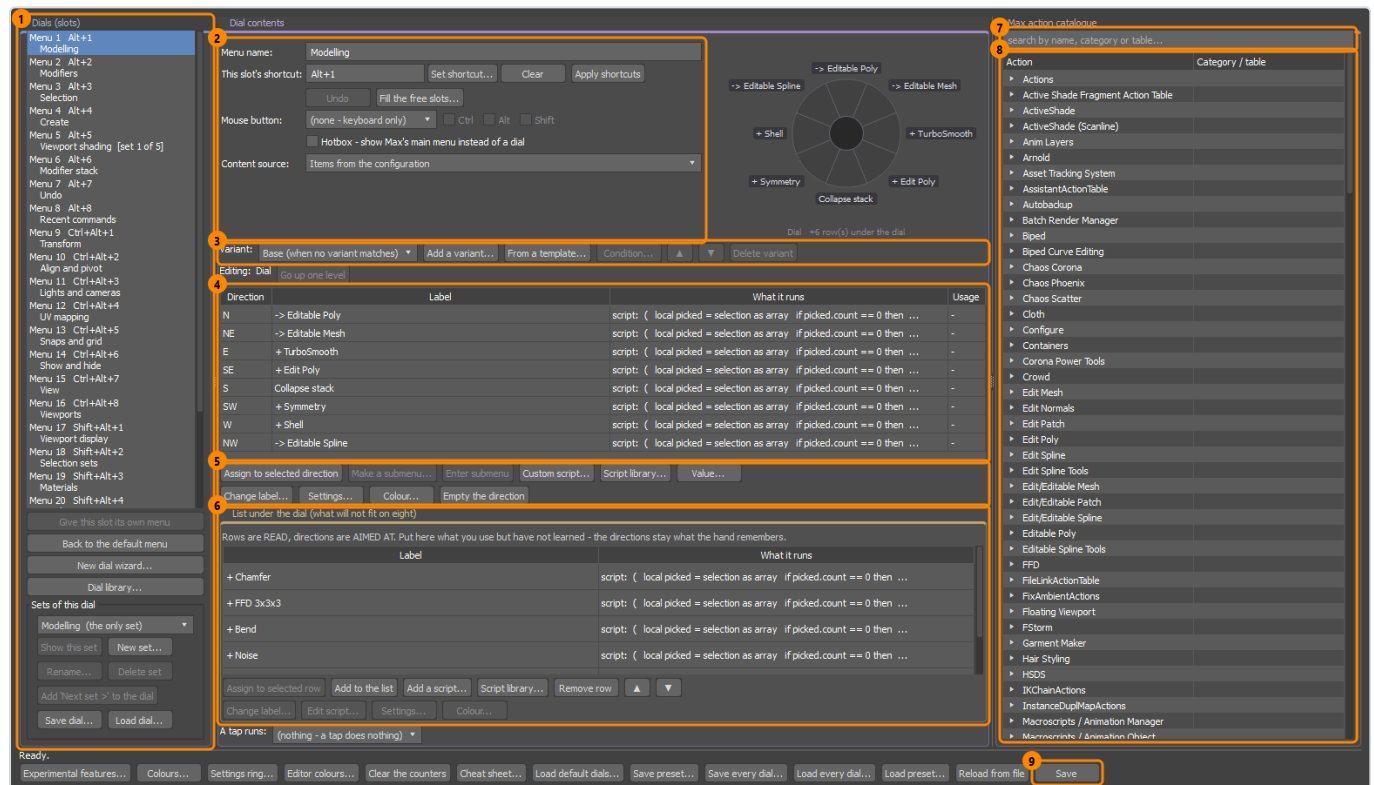
Four lessons. Nothing changes until you press **Save**.

6

Open the editor

1 min

MarkingForge > Menu editor...



The menu editor.

1. The 24 dials - click one to change it.
2. Its name, key and mouse button.
3. Variants - versions of the dial for other situations (lesson 8).
4. The eight directions.
5. Buttons for the selected direction.
6. Extra rows under the dial.
7. Search box.
8. Every 3ds Max command.
9. Save.

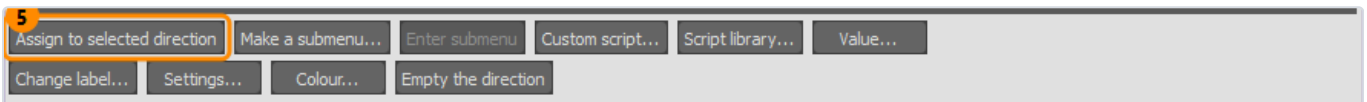
7

Put your own command on a dial

3 min

Example: on the File dial (Shift+Alt+8), put **Export Selected** down-right.

- 1 Click **Menu 24** in the list of dials.
- 2 Type `Export Selected` in the search box and click the command.
- 3 Click the **SE** row in the directions table.
- 4 Press **Assign to selected direction** under the table (or double-click the command).
- 5 Press **Save**.



The button under the directions table.

Direction	Label	What it runs	Usage
N	Save	action: Main UI	-
NE	Save as...	action: Main UI	-
E	Save incremental	action: Main UI	-
SE	Export Selected...	action: Main UI (name from Max)	-
S	Open...	action: Main UI	-
SW	Import...	action: Main UI	-
W	Merge...	action: Main UI	-
NW	Hold	action: Main UI	-

SE now runs Export Selected.

TRY IT

Hold Shift+Alt+8 over a viewport: down-right is Export Selected.

8

Variants: the dial changes by itself

4 min

In lesson 2 Alt+1 showed other tools for vertices and for polygons. Those are **variants**: other versions of the same dial, each with a **condition**. When you press the key, the dial shows the first variant whose condition is true - and its normal contents, the **base**, when none is.

Example: after lesson 7, down-right on the File dial is **Export Selected**. With nothing selected it has nothing to export - so let that direction export the whole scene then.

- 1 Click **Menu 24** in the list of dials.
- 2 Press **Add a variant...** - in the *Variant* row above the directions table.
- 3 In the window that opens, set **Selection** to *nothing selected* and press **OK**. The new variant starts as a copy of the dial, and the *Variant* list now shows it.
- 4 Type `Export` in the search box, click **Export...**, click the **SE** row and press **Assign to selected direction**.
- 5 Press **Save**.

The variant appears when ALL the filled-in fields match at once.
A field left empty means 'any' - it is not tested.

Object class:

Object kind:

Object name:

Layer:

Modifier in the panel:

Has modifier:

Sub-object level:

Cursor over the window:

Selection:

Condition: when selection: nothing selected

With the current selection: MATCHES (selected: 0 | class: '-' | superclass: '-' | subobject: 0 | modifier: '-' | object: '-' | layer: '-' context source: selection (nothing under the cursor) | hit test: 0,000 ms)

Selection set to *nothing selected*. Fill in only what must be true - an empty field is not tested.

TRY IT

Click empty space in a viewport so nothing is selected and hold Shift+Alt+8: down-right is Export.
Select an object: it is Export Selected again.

A variant can appear when...	For example
the object is of a class or kind	Editable Poly, any light
a modifier is open in the Modify panel	Unwrap UVW, Edit Poly
you are on a sub-object level	vertices, polygons
the cursor is over a window	the Slate material editor, the UV editor
the object's name or layer matches	wall_*, the layer Walls
this many objects are selected	nothing, one, two or more

To change the base again, pick **Base** in the *Variant* list. The first variant that matches wins, so a narrow one goes above a wide one - ▲ and ▼ move it.

9

Save, start again, share

2 min

Button (bottom of the editor)	What it does
Save	Your dials work at once.

Reload from file	Throws away what you have not saved.
Load default dials...	The dials MarkingForge came with. Tick <i>Replace...</i> to get all of them back.
Save preset... / Load preset...	Your whole layout in one file - to keep or share.

If something goes wrong

What happens	What to do
Holding the key does nothing	MarkingForge > Set up standard shortcuts...
I changed something, but the dial is the same	Press Save in the editor.
I want the original dials back	Editor: Load default dials... , tick <i>Replace...</i> , Save.
Where is the hotbox?	Hold Alt+5 and turn the mouse wheel one step away from you.
A caption is red	That command is not in this 3ds Max. Put another one there.
My variant never shows	Select it and press Condition... - the line at the bottom says whether it matches what is selected now. A variant higher in the list may match first.

Want more? The full QuickStart shows ready-made variant templates, scripts, number sliders, colours, more pages on one key and the dial library.

Support, bug reports and feature requests

ISSUES	github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues
ROADMAP	trello.com/b/7gJVqG8Y/markingforge-features-roadmap
E-MAIL	forgeplugins@gmail.com
WEB	https://forgeplugins.tech (forgeplugins.tech - more plugins by the author)

Bug reports and feature requests are best opened as issues on GitHub - the forms there ask for exactly what is needed, and you can follow the fix. Questions, and anything you would rather not post publicly (licence, purchase), go to the e-mail address. Every message is read.

Reporting a bug

- 1 In 3ds Max choose **MarkingForge > Report a bug...** - it copies your 3ds Max version, MarkingForge version, configuration summary and start-up log to the clipboard. It works even when the plugin did not load.
- 2 Open github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues and pick **Bug report** - or write an e-mail to forgeplugins@gmail.com instead. Both are links in the window that opens (since 1.5.20), one click each.
- 3 Say what you did, what you expected and what happened instead, then paste the details with **Ctrl+V**.
- 4 Add a screenshot if you can. When the problem is in one dial, attach a preset of it (editor > **Save preset...**).

Suggesting a feature

Open an issue with the **Feature request** form, choose **MarkingForge > Suggest a feature...**, or simply write. Describe what you would like to do and how you do it today - a concrete example from your work says more than a list of wishes. Ideas for new built-in dials, commands and options are all welcome. What is already planned and in progress is on the **Roadmap** above - **MarkingForge > Roadmap (Trello)** opens it too.

Nothing is sent by the plugin itself: the details go to the clipboard and your own e-mail program, so you see everything that leaves your computer. MarkingForge has no network access.